

# Iowa - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG TEN

**Legend:** trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

## 1. 60-Second Briefing

### Initial conclusions

| Question             | Answer                                                                                                                              |
|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| How good?            | <b>Top-25 / ranked-caliber with a high defensive floor, but QB, OL, front-seven and specialist turnover add real volatility.</b>    |
| Preseason consensus  | SP+ No.22 (+14.6) · AP No.22 (260 points)                                                                                           |
| Returning production | <b>44% - No.102 overall</b> · Off. <b>48% - No.89</b> · Def. <b>40% - No.106</b>                                                    |
| Primer power rating  | <b>+14.5</b> points vs. average FBS                                                                                                 |
| Expected season      | <b>8.0 wins</b> · most likely <b>8-4</b>                                                                                            |
| Net vs. 2025         | ● ↓ <b>Worse</b> - Major QB/OL/front-seven/secondary/specialist losses outweigh strong staff continuity and several proven anchors. |
| Confidence           | <b>Medium-low</b>                                                                                                                   |

**2026 identity:** OC Tim Lester leans on veteran RB/TE groups while a new QB and rebuilt OL settle. DC Phil Parker's defense remains the defining strength despite a younger front and reworked back end.

**Bottom line:** Iowa still profiles as a ranked-caliber eight-win team, but QB, OL, defensive-front and specialist churn create more volatility than the No. 22 label suggests.

**Beats expectations if:** QB Hank Brown or QB Jeremy Hecklinski becomes an efficient low-mistake distributor, OL Kade Pieper/OL Trevor Lauck stabilize the best-five offensive line, and Parker's new front rotation gets enough pressure without exposing the reworked secondary.

**Disappoints if:** The quarterback decision remains unsettled in performance terms, the rebuilt offensive line cannot reproduce 2025's disruption avoidance, and the defensive front/specialist turnover removes too many hidden-yardage and field-position advantages at once.

### Five things to remember

- 1 **? QB battle:** QB Hank Brown and QB Jeremy Hecklinski were still splitting top reps as of Aug. 22; no starter is named.
- 2 **National baseline:** Iowa returns only 44% of overall production (No.102), including 40% on defense (No.106), despite opening No.22 in both SP+ and the AP poll.
- 3 **Offensive line:** Three 2025 starting offensive linemen-C Logan Jones, OL Gennings Dunker and OL Beau Stephens-were NFL draft picks; OL Pieper and OL Lauck are the two identified 2026 anchors.
- 4 **2025 baseline:** The 2025 defense was genuinely elite by opponent-adjusted rating (No.9) and EPA/play allowed (No.6), but the front replaces DT Aaron Graves, DE Ethan Hurkett, DL Max Llewellyn, DT Jonah Pace and others.
- 5 **Schedule pressure:** The defining schedule sequence is at Michigan → Ohio State → at Washington before the Oct. 17 bye.

## 2. 2025 in Context

### Traditional Stats

| Measure         | 2025                                | Assessment             |
|-----------------|-------------------------------------|------------------------|
| Record          | 9-4 (6-3 Big Ten)                   | ● Good                 |
| Scoring         | 29.3 PPG                            | ● Average / mixed      |
| Total offense   | 320.1 YPG                           | ● Poor                 |
| Rush offense    | 176.9 YPG · 4.6 YPC                 | ● Good / above average |
| Pass efficiency | 6.51 YPA · 12 TD / 8 INT            | ● Below average        |
| Third downs     | 43.5%                               | ● Very good            |
| Scoring defense | 16.1 PPG allowed                    | ● Elite                |
| Total defense   | 280.4 YPG allowed                   | ● Elite                |
| Rush defense    | 107.7 YPG · 3.4 YPC                 | ● Very good            |
| Pass defense    | 172.7 YPG · 6.03 YPA · 9 TD allowed | ● Elite                |

Iowa’s 2025 identity was defense-first: scoring defense No.8, total defense No.9, rush defense No.17 and pass-efficiency defense No.11. The offense scored a respectable 29.3 points per game and ran well (No.42 rushing), but total offense was No.119 and pass efficiency No.90.

### Advanced Stats

| Measure                          | 2025            | Assessment             |
|----------------------------------|-----------------|------------------------|
| Opp.-adjusted offense            | +4.67 · No. 26  | ● Very good            |
| Off. EPA/play                    | +0.056 · No. 46 | ● Good / above average |
| Off. success rate                | 44.3% · No. 50  | ● Good / above average |
| Off. explosive-play rate         | 11.6% · No. 82  | ● Average / mixed      |
| Havoc allowed                    | 10.9% · No. 6   | ● Elite                |
| Opp.-adjusted defense            | +9.36 · No. 9   | ● Elite                |
| Def. EPA/play allowed            | -0.191 · No. 6  | ● Elite                |
| Def. success rate allowed        | 39.0% · No. 38  | ● Good / above average |
| Def. explosive-play rate allowed | 9.7% · No. 19   | ● Very good            |
| Havoc created                    | 16.6% · No. 46  | ● Good / above average |

**Advanced-stat read:** Iowa again paired a below-average offense with elite defense. The defense’s efficiency and explosive-play prevention support the floor, while offensive improvement depends on turning strong OL/RB continuity into more passing value.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

## 3. Coaching

| Role             | 2026 status                                          | Quick impact                                                            |
|------------------|------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| HC               | <b>Kirk Ferentz</b> - returning                      | ● ↔ Long-running program continuity keeps the structural floor high.    |
| OC / play-caller | <b>Tim Lester</b> - returning; offensive play-caller | ● ↔ Year-three offensive continuity matters while the QB and OL reset.  |
| DC               | <b>Phil Parker</b> - returning                       | ● ↔ Defensive continuity remains Iowa’s strongest structural advantage. |

## 4. Key Roster Movement

### Offense

| In              | From   | Expected effect                                                                                                               |
|-----------------|--------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ◆ WR Evan James | Furman | ● ↔ Newcomer singled out in camp and a live rotation candidate, but no information supports treating him as a proven upgrade. |
| ◆ WR Tony Diaz  | UTRGV  | ● ↔ Another newcomer singled out in an unsettled receiver competition; useful replacement option with translation risk.       |

| Out                | To                                | Loss                                                                                                                                        |
|--------------------|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| QB Mark Gronowski  | NFL (Miami), undrafted free agent | ● ↓ The 2025 starting quarterback and offensive MVP/captain leaves, creating the unresolved QB Hank Brown/QB Jeremy Hecklinski competition. |
| C Logan Jones      | NFL (Chicago), Round 2, No. 57    | ● ↓ Second-round departure removes the 2025 starting center and the most proven piece of a line replacing three starters.                   |
| OL Gennings Dunker | NFL (Pittsburgh), Round 3, No. 96 | ● ↓ Third-round NFL departure is part of the three-starter offensive-line reset.                                                            |
| OL Beau Stephens   | NFL (Seattle), Round 5, No. 148   | ● ↓ Fifth-round NFL departure completes the three-drafted-starter OL loss.                                                                  |

**Offensive net:** ● ↓ clear downgrade in high-leverage continuity, partially buffered by veteran RB/TE groups and year-three scheme familiarity.

### Defense

| In                  | From          | Expected effect                                                                                                                                                   |
|---------------------|---------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ◆ S Anthony Hawkins | Villanova     | ● ↔ Working significant reps during S Tyler Brown’s limitation and gives the secondary a material replacement option, but the starting distribution remains open. |
| ◆ S Tyler Brown     | James Madison | ● ↔ Live secondary contender whose camp evaluation is constrained by a muscle strain.                                                                             |

| Out              | To                                      | Loss                                                                                                                                      |
|------------------|-----------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| DT Aaron Graves  | NFL (Baltimore), undrafted free agent   | ● ↓ The 2025 starter (37 tackles, 6.5 TFL, five sacks) is a material front loss.                                                          |
| DE Ethan Hurkett | NFL (Kansas City), undrafted free agent | ● ↓ The 2025 starter (10.5 TFL, eight sacks) is a material front loss.                                                                    |
| DL Max Llewellyn | NFL (Miami), Round 7, No. 238           | ● ↓ Seventh-round NFL departure adds another starting-caliber loss to a front already replacing DT Graves/DE Hurkett/DT Pace.             |
| LB Karson Sharar | NFL (Arizona), Round 6, No. 183         | ● ↓ Major linebacker departure increases the burden on LB Jayden Montgomery and a less-established supporting cast.                       |
| DB TJ Hall       | NFL (New Orleans), Round 7, No. 219     | ● ↓ Veteran secondary starter/major contributor leaves amid multiple other veteran back-end departures.                                   |
| S Xavier Nwankpa | NFL (Kansas City), undrafted free agent | ● ↓ Extensive starting experience exits to the professional ranks, reducing back-end continuity behind DB Zach Lutmer and DB Deshaun Lee. |

**Defensive net:** ● ↓ meaningful downgrade in proven front-seven and secondary continuity, with Parker’s system and a few veteran anchors preserving a strong baseline.

## 5. How They Play

| Phase         | Identity                                                                                                         | What works                                                                                                | Main vulnerability                                                                  |
|---------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Offense       | Year-three Tim Lester/Shanahan system built around veteran RB/TE groups while QB and OL settle.                  | RB Kamari Moulton and the TE room provide continuity; 2025 havoc allowed was elite.                       | No named QB1 and three NFL-drafted OL departures create passing-down risk.          |
| Defense       | DC Phil Parker keeps the disciplined efficiency-first identity with a new front rotation and reworked secondary. | LB Jayden Montgomery and veteran DBs anchor a unit that was elite in adjusted efficiency.                 | Heavy front-seven and DB losses leave several roles open.                           |
| Special teams | Strong inherited model signal with almost none of the key 2025 specialist/return-role continuity.                | The SP+ signal supports a top-10 special-teams baseline, while K Eli Ozick carries Lou Groza recognition. | Kicker, punter, long snapper and returner are all unsettled after major departures. |

## 6. Unit Grades

| Unit          | Grade | vs. 2025 | Confidence  | Why                                                                                          |
|---------------|-------|----------|-------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| QB            | ● C+  | ● ↓      | Low         | QB Hank Brown and QB Jeremy Hecklinski are still competing to replace the 2025 starter.      |
| RB            | ● B+  | ● ↔      | Medium-high | RB Kamari Moulton anchors one of the offense’s safest veteran groups.                        |
| WR            | ● C+  | ● ↔      | Medium-low  | Veteran reference points return, but the receiver rotation remains unsettled.                |
| TE            | ● B+  | ● ↑      | High        | TE DJ Vonnahme and a veteran room should carry more of the offensive burden.                 |
| OL            | ● B–  | ● ↓      | Low         | OL Kade Pieper and OL Trevor Lauck anchor a line replacing three NFL-drafted starters.       |
| DL/Edge       | ● B–  | ● ↓      | Low         | The front replaces multiple veteran starters and still needs a new rotation to emerge.       |
| LB            | ● B–  | ● ↓      | Medium      | LB Jayden Montgomery is the anchor after several material departures.                        |
| Secondary     | ● B   | ● ↓      | Medium-low  | DB Zach Lutmer and DB Deshaun Lee provide a base, but multiple veterans are gone.            |
| Special teams | ● B–  | ● ↓      | Low         | The model signal is strong, but kicker, punter, snapper and returner all reset.              |
| Coaching      | ● A   | ● ↔      | High        | HC Kirk Ferentz, OC Tim Lester and DC Phil Parker provide elite continuity.                  |
| Overall       | ● B+  | ● ↓      | Medium-low  | <b>Top-25 baseline, but low returning production raises line, front and specialist risk.</b> |

## 7. Players to Know

**Recognition status:** preseason honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 22, 2026.

| Player            | Pos.  | Evaluation                                                            | Preseason recognition                                                                | Why he matters                                                                                                                                                      |
|-------------------|-------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Kade Pieper       | OL    | ● <b>High-end conference starter / national-honors caliber anchor</b> | AP 1st team · Walter Camp 1st team · Big Ten preseason honoree · Outland · Rimington | The clearest proven piece of a line replacing three NFL-drafted starters; his center/guard alignment is part of the best-five search.                               |
| Kamari Moulton    | RB    | ● <b>High-end conference lead-back projection</b>                     | Doak Walker                                                                          | The veteran RB room is one of the safest offensive anchors while Iowa breaks in a new quarterback and rebuilt line.                                                 |
| Jayden Montgomery | LB    | ● <b>High-end conference starter / defensive anchor</b>               | Butkus                                                                               | The named linebacker anchor after Sharar, Harrell and Rexroth depart.                                                                                               |
| Zach Lutmer       | DB/PR | ● <b>High-end conference starter / secondary leader</b>               | Bednarik · Bronko Nagurski                                                           | One of the two named back-end leaders and the current first punt-return option while Iowa replaces multiple veteran defensive backs and Kaden Wetjen’s return role. |

| Player            | Pos. | Evaluation                                         | Preseason recognition | Why he matters                                                                                                                   |
|-------------------|------|----------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Trevor Lauck      | OL   | ● <b>Above-average Power 4 starter / OL anchor</b> | Outland               | One of only two returning line anchors explicitly identified by Ferentz.                                                         |
| DJ Vonnahme       | TE   | ● <b>High-end conference starter candidate</b>     | John Mackey           | Part of a veteran TE room that should carry more offensive burden during the QB/OL transition.                                   |
| Hank Brown        | QB   | ● <b>Unproven starter candidate</b>                | -                     | One half of the unresolved top-rep quarterback competition; the offensive ceiling depends heavily on the winner being efficient. |
| Jeremy Hecklinski | QB   | ● <b>Unproven starter candidate</b>                | -                     | Splitting top reps with QB Hank Brown as of Aug. 22; neither player is named QB1.                                                |

## 8. Schedule

| Item            | Assessment                                                                                                                                                        |
|-----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Overall         | <b>Manageable in aggregate for a top-25 team, but the Michigan/Ohio State/Washington sequence can punish any slow start from the rebuilt offense and defense.</b> |
| Difficulty      | ● <b>7/10</b> · Hard · SP+ SOS No. 33                                                                                                                             |
| Hardest stretch | at Michigan → Ohio State → at Washington                                                                                                                          |
| Swing games     | Iowa State, at Minnesota, Wisconsin, at Northwestern, at Illinois, Nebraska                                                                                       |
| Advantage       | Three straight home games open the season, including Northern Illinois, Iowa State and UNI, giving the new QB/OL time before the first road trip.                 |
| Expected        | <b>8.0 wins</b> · most likely <b>8-4</b>                                                                                                                          |
| Floor / ceiling | <b>6-6 / 10-2</b>                                                                                                                                                 |

## 9. Betting Lens

| Angle           | Read                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|-----------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Market posture  | AP/SP+ No. 22 rewards Iowa's floor, but the offensive transition is not only about passing; replacing QB Mark Gronowski's run-game and compressed-field value could matter even if the new quarterback throws well. |
| Back them when  | The QB protects the ball, the OL stabilizes and the matchup favors a lower-possession game.                                                                                                                         |
| Fade/pass when  | The market assumes 2025 defensive/special-teams continuity before the new front and specialists prove it.                                                                                                           |
| Key monitor     | Official QB1 and whether the competition extends into games, Final offensive-line five and center/guard alignment, Defensive-front rotation, S Tyler Brown / Kyler Gerardy availability, K/P/LS/returner winners    |
| Week 1 baseline | <b>Iowa -33.5 vs. Northern Illinois</b> · early rating-based fair value; compare with the live market before betting. <b>Live market: Iowa -31.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).</b>                                         |

## 10. Summary

Iowa's floor remains sturdy because the veteran OL/RB core and elite secondary fit the program's preferred low-variance style. The offense has more quarterback upside than a year ago, but receiver production still has to emerge.

The defense should remain good even with meaningful DL/LB turnover, and special teams stays a strength. The schedule keeps **8.1 wins** · **likely 8-4** realistic, with offensive explosiveness the clearest path above that baseline.

### About this primer

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